India Office pointed out that 'there is little evidence to support the theory of Bolshevik or enemy instigation' in the outbreak of the Afghan war. Instead, the report contended, it was the weakness of the new emir's position, combined with the news of unrest in India, that encouraged Amanullah to take the opportunity to strike and re-assert Afghanistan's international authority.[141] Hamilton Grant concurred, believing that one of the chief reasons for the outbreak of the conflict had been the mistaken belief in Afghanistan that the tribes along the Indian border, together with the Indian people, would rebel against the British government.[142]

Furthermore, there was evidence to suggest that the Afghan government was using relations with Moscow as a bargaining tool against Britain. As Hamilton Grant reported to the Indian government, the Afghan delegation at Rawalpindi 'was obviously briefed to try and frighten us with the Bolshevik bogey'.[143] Indeed, they openly threatened the Indian government when they asserted during the negotiations that 'if you fight with us we can fight with you, and we will get help from the Bolshevists and fight against you. If the Bolshevists fight against you, we shall help them and welcome them. But if you are our friend, we can prevent them by force.'[144] Aware of the vulnerability of his position, Amanullah was effectively playing the best card he had – inviting into his country Bolshevik and Indian revolutionaries in order to demonstrate his ability to cause trouble for the Indian government.[145] Hamilton Grant's reaction was, in effect, to call the Afghans' bluff, by arguing that Britain had no fear of Bolshevism taking hold in India, since the Indians themselves would not let that happen, and that the government could quite easily close all the northern passes between the two countries if need be.[146]

Nevertheless, while Hamilton Grant could not afford to appear anything less than entirely self-assured in front of the Afghan delegation, this did not mean that the Indian government totally dismissed the potential danger of Bolshevism. For, as Dobbs explained, the Bolshevik regime 'might ally itself with Afghanistan and help it with men and arms against India. Or it might conceivably conquer Afghanistan as an obstacle on the road to plunder India.'[147] This threat was, however, not entirely different to that which had been posed by the tsarist regime and had, indeed, been the very basis of the Great Game. The Indian government well understood how to